Media Arts: Sociopolitical Development of Urban Youth of Color

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Introduction

Young people, especially urban youth of color, frequently bare the burden of societal inequalities and disparities. For example: Native and African American youth are arrested, adjudicated and incarcerated at rates significantly higher than their White counterparts (Child Trends Databank, 2009; Hartney, 2008). Nearly twenty-nine percent of Native American youth (in some areas up to fifty percent) do not graduate high school (Engle, 2010; U.S. Census Bureau, 2006). Only thirty-six percent of African American and twenty-eight percent of Hispanic youth ages eighteen to twenty-four are enrolled in post-secondary institutions (U.S. Census Bureau, 2000) and only eleven percent of Native Americans hold a bachelors degree (U.S. Census Bureau, 2006) . In addition, urban youth of color disproportionately face "social toxins" like negative imagery and stereotypes, lack of community resources and opportunities like ACT preparation, transportation, and community recreation centers and a hyper presence of "social services". There are few programs in the inner city that address the unique academic, personal, emotional, and health needs of these youth and the research on urban youth of color often focuses on individual, family, and community risks and fails to capitalize on the strengths of urban youth and the complexity of their development within these unique socio-political contexts.

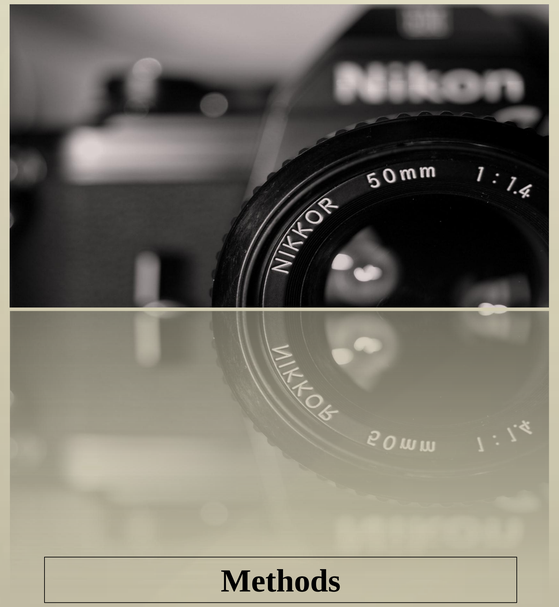
Significance of the Study

A significant portion of the literature on youth development focuses on individual, family, and community risk. A large amount of this research uses measures that reinforce white, middle class norms of development. As such, it dismisses the unique developmental needs of youth who face societal inequalities. Urban youth are not often given the opportunity to voice their opinions or to engage these inequalities. "Social Justice Youth Development (SJYD) examines how urban youth contest, challenge, respond to, and negotiate the use and misuse of power in their lives" (Ginwright & James, 2002). There is a need for more research on Social Justice Youth Development, especially among urban Native American youth. One way to bring about change in communities facing racial and economic inequalities is to provide space where youth become active participants in their development and are given opportunities to address their communities needs. My research project explores how SJYD contributes to the development of urban Native youth in the Minneapolis-St. Paul area.

Research Question

How does a media arts program contribute to the sociopolitical development of urban youth of color?





Methods

•The research question was explored as part of a larger Youth Participatory Action Research project entitled: "An Evaluation of Youth Development in Media Arts Programs in the Twin Cities."

•According to Fossey et al. Participatory Action Research "[A]ims to engage key stakeholders as participants in the design and conduct of the research, diminishing the distinction between the 'researcher' and the 'researched'."

•Over ten weeks youth participants learned about Critical Media Literacy and produced 5 media projects on community issues of their choice (pre-production, production, and post-production).

DATA COLLECTION
•Participant-observations field notes were collected over the course of the 10 week program. Field notes included descriptive observations of behaviors, experiences and interactions of youth participants, and daily reflections of the researcher.

DATA ANALYSIS
•Data was analyzed for themes and coded for patterns guided by the theory of Social Justice Youth Development.

Preliminary Results

Awareness of Oppressive Forces in their lives	Limited Spaces to Engage Awareness	Media as a form of expression/ engagement	Strong Sense of Self
• "Where I live there is a lot of violence, poverty, drug dealers, prostitutes, and unfair cops." • "I live where politics control everything. It is wrapped into out everyday lives." • "I live where there are only a few cops. They don't care what happens in my community."	• "A voice is worth something even when no one is listening, Eventually someone might start to listen." • "I don't do anything to let my voice be heard. I don't know anyone that looks at things the way I do."	• "My city is a melting pot, cultures flowing over the top. 10,000 lakes, multiple places to drown. I will never frown as long as I got Southside pride on my side and in my stride." • "Bring about awareness of issues to people in power." • "I can get involved with city council to change my community."	• "Here being Native is cool." • "I am the calm before the storm. I'm 50/50 love and hate, most days unbalanced. I live to learn, I live to think. I am the definition of natural strength. My family is my stone. As I am made of happiness, peace, and love I shall never be alone."

Discussion

This Youth Participatory Action Research Project examines how one media arts program contributes to the sociopolitical development of urban youth of color. Although findings are preliminary, they show that the Summer Media Institute (SMI) fostered a deeper awareness of oppressive forces and began to explore ways to collectively combat these forces. By promoting this awareness SMI increases critical consciousness among its participants and further engages them in socio-political development and the process of social justice and change. Although preliminary, these results have the potential to impact youth policy, practice, and future research.

The findings suggest:
-SJYD programs have the potential to positively impact urban youth and to engage them in social change.
-SJYD should be incorporated in urban youth development work. More spaces need to be opened for young people to actively engage in their development and use their voices.
-Continued research is needed to explore how media arts programs in particular, support urban youth development and what methods appear to work most effectively. Future research should continue to explore elements of sociopolitical development and longitudinal research would help to strengthen our understanding of the impact of SJYD programs over time.

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